

also started looking at the Internet in terms of business viability.

In 1994, Pizza Hut started offering pizza ordering on its Web page while First Virtual, the first 'cyberbank', launched its online presence. By this time, there were more than 3,864,000 hosts on the Internet. Since then, the Net has grown rapidly and the process continues to this day.

India And The Internet

The Internet hit India in the late 1980s, although it was again deemed fit only for researchers and scientists. In 1987, the first dial-up e-mail network was set up between NCST and IIT-Mumbai. In 1988, an international dial-up e-mail network connected NSCT in Bombay to a host in Amsterdam. In 1994, a satellite communications network was set up with assistance from the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP). Later in August 1995, VSNL introduced commercial Internet access in India, with a student shell account becoming available for Rs 750 while a TCP/IP account cost somewhere in the vicinity of Rs 15,000-16,000.

After VSNL's Internet access monopoly was curbed by the Indian government on November 6, 1998, there was a major spurt in the number of ISPs including Mantra Online, Dishnet DSL and others who became major players. Some of these ISPs are now either defunct or have been bought over by other companies.

Today, Internet in India has ballooned and India has become a giant in the ITES or IT Enabled Services field. With falling Internet access costs and increasing users, India's ranking in terms of Internet users is rising fast. According to statistics, more than 50 million Internet users are abound in India with a large number of potential users waiting to go online.

One of the major influences of India being in the mammoth "Internet ready" stream is the increasing advancements in infrastructure and innovations in technology making it easier for even people in rural parts of the country to have access to the Internet.